

Supporting a Struggling Team Member

Helping without overplaying or fleeing

4 psychology approaches · tips & guidance — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Helping without overplaying or fleeing

A team member is struggling — overload, lost motivation, signs of distress, personal difficulties spilling over. As a manager, you're neither a therapist nor indifferent: there's a right stance.

This guide helps you understand what the situation stirs in you, find the right stance, and support concretely — by directing toward the right channels.

Your intention

A team member's situation that worries you: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

What it stirs in you

Facing someone struggling, a manager may feel discomfort, fear of doing it wrong, the urge to avoid the subject... or conversely to carry it all for them.

Recognizing your reaction helps you stay present without losing yourself.

Example

Uneasy with a colleague's distress, Marc avoided him. Understanding his discomfort let him dare to open the dialogue.

My reaction

Facing this, what dominates in you (discomfort, fear, urge to flee, to fix it all)?

My right place

Write what's your role / what's others' (HR, care, the person themselves).

→ *I can be present without being a therapist or a rescuer.*

The thoughts that block helping

'It's not my role', 'I'll make things worse', 'I must rescue them': these thoughts lead either to avoidance or over-involvement.

Softening them opens a middle way: supporting.

Example

Sure she'd 'make it worse' by speaking, Nia opened with a simple question. The colleague felt relieved to be seen.

Blockers journal

Note: the thought that blocks you · a fairer version.

Reframe my role

Turn 'I must rescue them' into 'I can listen, adjust what depends on me, and direct'.

→ *My role: listen, adjust, direct — not solve everything.*

The right stance

The right stance is listening without diagnosing, welcoming without overplaying, respecting without abandoning. Sincere presence often matters more than solutions.

Being seen and heard already helps.

Example

By simply saying 'I can see it's hard right now, how can I help?', Léa opened a real dialogue.

Listen, not diagnose

Prepare 1-2 caring, non-intrusive opening lines.

Presence before solutions

Write what you can offer first (listening, time) before any 'solution'.

→ *Sincere presence often matters more than solutions.*

Supporting concretely

Concretely: open the dialogue (open questions, in private), adjust what depends on you (workload, deadlines), direct toward the right channels (HR, occupational health, a helpline), follow up, and know your limits.

Directing isn't offloading: it's offering the right help.

Example

After listening and adjusting the workload, Sofia directed her team member to occupational health — and checked in a week later.

My levers & channels

Note: what I can adjust (workload, deadlines) · the channels to direct to (HR, occupational health, helpline).

My follow-up

When and how to check in kindly, without surveilling?

→ *Listen, adjust, direct, follow up — and know my limits.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Open the dialogue with kindness and discretion (open questions, in private).
- Listen without diagnosing or minimizing.
- You're not a therapist: your role is to listen, adjust what depends on you, and direct.
- Direct toward the right channels (HR, occupational health, a helpline) and respect confidentiality.
- Adjust the workload if possible, follow up, and take care of yourself too.
- In case of serious distress or danger, contact emergency services/professionals immediately.

To fill in

My support

What I open/say	What I adjust	Whom I direct to

My follow-up

When	How (without surveilling)

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Understand what the situation stirs in me.

Week 2 — Soften the thoughts that block helping.

Week 3 — Adopt the right stance (listen, presence).

Week 4 — Support: dialogue, adjustment, channels, follow-up.

Your plan in 3 lines

- My caring opening line:
- What I can adjust:
- The channel I direct to:

TO CLOSE

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This guide is a coaching tool for managers — not a certified training, nor legal or medical advice. For health matters, rely on occupational health and qualified professionals. In case of serious distress or danger, contact emergency services immediately. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.